HITL-DRIVEN ARCHITECTURE

The Shock Wave Effect

How change propagates through an organization — and what happens when it hits multiple domains at once

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Working idea, not yet part of the built framework. This page exists to sharpen a concept, not to report a finished metric or feature — for joint discussion, not a settled position. Refreshed October 29, 2026 against the current architecture — activity-level RACI (GR-060), decision points (GR-021), the work-element model (GR-058) and activity-level CRUD — after GiGi marked it Needs Revision on October 28. Every figure below is modeled from Sandbox 7.0's Reference Model at its Progression Ceilings, with the same rules the sandbox's four views use.

RELATED REQUIREMENTS — REQUIREMENTS REGISTER

- **GR-021** — Human Accountability Anchor and decision points *(Built — every activity's anchor is its Accountable role; 85 decision points, 12 activities needing a named control)*
- **GR-060** — RACI at the activity level *(Built — one Accountable role per activity; process RACI computed from it)*
- **GR-042** — Governed Decision Point record *(In progress — eight fields, required by Consequence of Error)*
- **GR-046** — work product in the role container *(Designed — verification points and unchecked hand-offs computed in the Data view)*
- **GR-029** / **GR-030** — Exception Escalation Effect and Accountability Concentration *(Designed — computed in the People view)*
- **GR-033** — seven-stage Human Impact Pathway *(Designed — GiGi's structured version of the rings)*
- **GR-024** — executive-facing per-role view *(Open)*

Where This Started

The Working Collaboration & Co-Development Principles document's Shared Vision paragraph names the real question underneath this whole partnership: when AI, or any other force, materially changes the work, what happens to the role, the person performing it, the manager leading it, the team around it, and the accountability for what follows?

> *"Our working vision is to create an integrated architecture for Human + AI Work — one that connects the architecture of work with the human consequences of changing that work."*

That question has a shape worth naming directly: it widens outward, ring by ring, from the point of impact. That's the shock wave — and once you see the org that way, two things follow. First, a single role's transformation propagates through five distinct rings, not one. Second, when several parts of the organization transform at once, those individual waves don't stay separate.

The Blast Radius of a Single Role

Ring	What Changes	Measured Today?
Role	The work itself — which activities move along the working-relationship ramp, from Human-only toward Automation, and how far each is allowed to go	Yes — each activity's Current State and Progression Ceiling, and who leads each of its seven work elements at every stage (GR-058)
Person	What the shift actually means for the person doing the work	Partial — the work elements show what stays with a person at each stage, and the People view shows what is left for each role as the work moves up. What it means for the person is the Human Impact & Readiness side (GR-012, GR-056)
Manager	The manager who has to lead someone through the change, redistribute what's left, and absorb the disruption to their own span of control	Partial — reporting lines, span of control, and where High and Critical exceptions land once the work runs on flagged exceptions (People view, GR-029). The cost of absorbing them is not measured
Team	The team around the role, absorbing whatever gets redistributed once the role itself changes	No — not yet built
Accountability	Who remains answerable for the decision or outcome, no matter how the underlying work changes	Yes — one Accountable role per activity, its Human Accountability Anchor (GR-060, GR-021), and a decision point wherever a person holds the decision. Held fixed by design, not expected to move

Decision point: an activity where a person holds its Decide element — or Verify, when it has no Decide — on every instance or on each flagged instance (GR-021). At the Reference Model's ceilings there are 85. An activity that is not one is decided or verified at the decision points on the work products it creates, updates or deletes; 12 activities reach none and need a named control, owned by their Accountable role. The **Governed Decision Point record** (GR-042, proposed) is what operationalizes the anchor: owner, what it decides or verifies, its work products, escalation path, override, documentation and review —

> more of it required the higher the Consequence of Error. It's the mechanism behind “accountability is held fixed.”

What's worth noticing: the two rings the framework already measures well — Role and Accountability — sit at the two ends of the wave, not in the middle. Accountability is deliberately built to hold its shape regardless of how hard the wave hits everything around it; that's the framework's own founding thesis (“AI can redistribute work. It cannot redistribute accountability.”) restated in blast-radius terms. The middle three rings — Person, Manager, Team — are where the actual human cost of the wave is absorbed, and it's exactly those rings where the framework is thinnest today.

Activity-level RACI makes a second thing visible. Accountability doesn’t move with the work, but it isn’t evenly spread either: three of the 14 roles — HRBP Manager (22), Director of HR Ops (15) and HRIS Analyst (15) — are Accountable for 52 of the 118 activities, 44%. As the work redistributes toward AI, those are the roles the wave keeps landing on. GiGi named this Accountability Concentration (GR-030): activity distributes to technology, accountability concentrates in fewer people.

GiGi’s seven-stage Human Impact Pathway (GR-033) asks the same questions ring by ring — what changed, who absorbs it, what new risk appeared, who now owns the outcome — and is the structured form of this picture on the human-transition side.

When Multiple Domains Detonate at Once

A single role's transformation is a contained event — hard at the center, weaker with distance, absorbable. The real risk sharpens when AI transformation hits several functional domains at the same time, uncoordinated, without any sequencing between them.

Overlapping shock waves don't simply add together — where two waves cross, they interfere, and the combined force at that intersection can exceed either wave alone. The organizational parallel is precise: a manager, a shared-services team, or a role sitting at the intersection of two or three functions transforming simultaneously doesn't experience double the disruption. They experience the interference pattern — no recovery time between hits, no slack nearby to borrow from, and the people and trust at exactly those overlap points failing first, before the damage is even visible anywhere else.

From Metaphor to Mechanism: Cascade, Not Annihilation

“Total nuclear destruction” is the right image for how it feels from inside an uncoordinated, multi-domain change effort — but the more precise and more defensible failure mode is cascading failure, the same vocabulary systems engineering and financial-contagion analysis use for interconnected systems. An

isolated failure is absorbable. A failure that hits multiple interconnected nodes at once, with nothing containing it, cascades: trust erodes organization-wide rather than locally, decision-making seizes up because accountability itself is overwhelmed, and the damage compounds faster than the organization can respond to any single piece of it.

That's a real and severe failure mode — and, importantly, a survivable and preventable one, which "total destruction" as a literal claim is not. The nuclear image works to make the stakes vivid; cascading failure is the mechanism to point to if the argument ever needs to hold up analytically rather than just land emotionally.

The Framework's Answer: Containment Through Sequencing

This isn't a hypothetical the framework has no response to. Three built mechanisms hold accountability in place as the work moves: every activity keeps one Accountable role; every activity where a person holds the decision is a decision point; and every activity that reaches no decision point is flagged as needing a named control rather than left unanswered. Add a phased, one-domain-at-a-time rollout rather than a simultaneous org-wide push, and together they are a containment strategy against exactly this failure mode. Sequencing keeps the shock waves from overlapping in the first place; governance keeps accountability from being one of the things that erodes if they do.

A Second Path: Work Product

The five rings trace the wave from a role out through people. Work product carries it a second way. An activity's output — a record, a review, a report — is relied on by other activities, and each of those has its own Accountable role. When AI produces or drafts that output, every activity that relies on it inherits a job: confirming it can be trusted before acting on it. GiGi named this the verification tax (HR Couch, Sept 23, 2026): "If AI saves someone ten hours but another employee spends six hours checking the work... we did not eliminate ten hours. We moved the work somewhere else."

The framework now traces where that work moves at the activity level. Each activity records which work products it creates, reads, updates and deletes; each has its own Accountable role; and its stage says how much of the work AI does. The Data view applies one rule (GR-046): a work product is AI-touched once its most automated producer is at Augmentation or further. An activity that relies on it at Judgment, Augmentation or Oversight is a *verification point* — a person checks it there. One that relies on it at Agent-delegation or Automation on High or Critical work is an *unchecked hand-off*: no person sees every instance, so it needs a named control.

Tracing the Performance Review: it is produced by three HRBP Manager activities — 7.3.2.1 Define employee performance objectives and 7.3.2.2 Review employee performance (both at Augmentation)

and 7.3.2.3 Document employee performance (at Oversight, where AI drafts the documentation and a person approves each one). At the ceilings, these activities rely on it:

Relies on the Performance Review	Accountable	Ceiling	Consequence of Error	Check
7.4.1 Manage labor relations	HRBP Manager	Augmentation	Critical	Verification point
7.6.1 Manage promotion and demotion	HRBP Manager	Augmentation	High	Verification point
7.1.2.3 Develop succession plan	SVP Talent Management	Augmentation	High	Verification point
7.3.3.4 Establish succession plans	Director of L&D	Augmentation	High	Verification point
7.3.3.2 Develop career plans and career paths	Director of L&D	Augmentation	Moderate	Verification point
7.5.1.5 Administer compensation and rewards	Compensation & Benefits Manager	Agent-delegation	High	Unchecked hand-off

Within 7.3.2 itself there are two more checks, where 7.3.2.2 and 7.3.2.3 rely on each other's work. Four more activities read it at Agent-delegation or Automation on Low or Moderate work (7.1.2.4, 7.3.2.4, 7.5.1.6, 7.7.7.5), where the rule asks for no check. So an AI-drafted review does not stop at the review: it reaches labor relations, promotion, succession, career and pay decisions. The verification tax lands on whoever is Accountable at each of those points — and at 7.5.1.5 nobody checks every instance: compensation administered at Agent-delegation relies on an AI-drafted review, which is exactly where a named control is needed. The HRBP Manager pays twice: once at the source, and again when their own labor relations and promotion decisions rely on it.

Running the same rule across all 49 work products: 29 are AI-touched where someone relies on them, with 80 verification points and 22 unchecked hand-offs on 9 activities. The load lands like this (roles with neither are not shown):

Accountable role	Verification points	Unchecked hand-offs	Pays twice on
HRBP Manager	24	9	10 work products, including the Performance Review, Grievance Case, ER Case Record and Employee Master Record
Director of HR Ops	11	0	5, including the Workforce Plan, Regulatory Alert and HR Analytics Report
Compensation & Benefits Manager	10	4	4: Compensation Record, Payroll Record, Compensation Plan, Benefits Plan
CHRO	9	0	1: HR Strategy
Director of L&D	9	1	3: Competency Model, Training Record, Succession Plan
Director of TA	6	1	2: Offer Letter, Applicant Record
HRIS Analyst	0	5	2: Employee Master Record, Time and Attendance Record
VP People & Culture, Recruiter, HR Generalist, SVP Talent Management	2–4 each	0–1 each	VP People & Culture 2, Recruiter 2

“Pays twice” means the role is Accountable both for producing a work product and for an activity that has to check it. The role that already holds the most Accountable activities in 7.0 — grievances, promotions, labor relations — is also where the most AI-produced work lands for checking, and where the most unchecked hand-offs sit. For each work product, four things are worth measuring:

- **Fan-out:** how many activities read it. The Employee Master Record is read by 18, the Competency Model by 13, the Performance Review by 10.
- **Consequence of what it feeds:** a review feeding a promotion decision matters more than one feeding a newsletter — now read straight from each relying activity’s Consequence of Error.
- **The verification point:** where an AI-produced output meets a person who checks it — where someone has to answer where it came from, whether it was verified, and who stands behind the decision.
- **Verification load:** the roles that sit at many verification points at once.

These counts are modeled, not observed: the Reference Model at its Progression Ceilings, with the Consequence of Error gates applied (CL-017), and activity-level CRUD confirmed for all 118 activities (CL-014). The sandbox’s Data view computes them live, at any stage or at an organization’s assessed Current State.

Open Questions

Manager and Team as measured rings. Both rings have structural data (reporting lines, span of control) and, for the manager, where escalated exceptions land — but no measure of force or load. This is the same open ground as the framework's Trust and load/sustainability gaps, named from a different direction.

Verification load as the first measure of the middle rings. Verification points and unchecked hand-offs per Accountable role are now a computed, repeatable signal of where load lands. They still count exposure, not hours; whether people can carry it is GiGi's side — GR-012's Capacity/Workload and Manager/Governance-Oversight Readiness, and Human Intensity — and turning it into effort would need observed data.

Whether interference is measurable, not just descriptive. Could the framework ever flag a real overlap — a manager or team sitting at the intersection of two simultaneously-transforming domains — before it happens, rather than only naming the concept after the fact?

Scope. Right now this is written from PCF 7.0 (HR) outward. Whether it stays a narrative frame or becomes something closer to a formal cross-domain lens is undecided.

For joint review — **Tim King** and **GiGi Garcia** · refreshed October 29, 2026

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